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(d) Sekuru and muzukuru • (e) Vakarahwe and vakwasha

[\(d\) Sekuru and muzukuru](#)

When explaining the structure of Hera kinship, considerable attention was given to this particular relationship and I need add very little to it, except that the *vazukuru kadzi* (granddaughters) seem to enjoy a privileged treatment similar to that of their brothers. But by the mere fact that these girls do not find *varamu* in the kraals of their m.b., with which they could make fun, coupled with a demure and modest behaviour which is generally expected from them, their position in the *vasekuru's* kraals is less spectacular than in the case of their brothers. I think it is clear that the 'joking relationship', between grandparents and grandchildren, that is, between members and uterine members of a lineage, has a logical and structural basis in Hera kinship.

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The basis of this relationship is partly brought out by the term *mukarahwe*. The literal translation, 'stone-sister', is also a literal description of the position of a 'father-in-law' in his son-in-law's kraal. As stated before, the Hera carefully observe the principle that a person of higher status should also have a higher seat than his inferiors. At the *civara* (or *dare*: open gathering place of a village) the kraalhead will sit on the highest stone, or only stone, while the other men will sit on lower stones, or flat on the ground. Whenever a *mukwasha* sits in the presence of his *mukarahwe* he will sit flat, and his 'father-in-law' will sit on the stone, even in the *mukwasha's* own village. The other term *tezware* (which, among these Hera, is only used with reference to

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younger males of the wife's lineage) reveals the organic aspect of the relationship, and is, from a genealogical point of view, probably more correct.

The general basis for this relationship is, therefore, clearly established: the *vakarahwe* are entitled to respectful treatment from their *vakwashab* because they are the 'higher' and the 'elder' ones. If one asks a Muhera what is expected from him as *mukwasha*, he may summarize his position as follows: a *mukwasha* should always 'honour' (respect, *kukudza*) and 'fear' (*kutya*) his *mukarahwe*. Whenever possible, and certainly at the *vakarahwe*'s first visit to the kraal he should 'kill meat' (*kuvurayenyama*), that is, he should slaughter and prepare a fowl or goat in honour of his father-in-law. He should further always be willing and prepared to work (*kubata*) for his *mukarahwe*. At collective beer-work parties (*nimbe*) held at the latter's kraal  47 he has 'to be very busy' (*kubata zwikuru*), and especially so when the occasion is connected with the fields of his wife's own mother. He should come earlier than anyone else and make the necessary preparations, e.g. cutting the threshing sticks, ¹ taking the grain out of the grain hut ² and spreading it over the threshing floor. ³ When his *mukarahwe*'s village needs repairs he should offer his help; when a new kraal has to be built he is expected to make the hut of his wife's mother. When he has had a succesful hunt he should never forget his in-laws. When he has trapped a nice fat rock-rabbit he should bring it to them. He is often sent on errands. He should willingly tolerate a fair amount of bullying from his wife's little brothers (his 'little fathers').

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¹ *Shamu* or *mipuro*.

² *Tsapi*.

³ *Ruwari* or *mbuwa*.

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